ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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# Google Workspace and Cloud Collaboration: Work Together Without Chaos

Shared documents, files and calendars that keep group assignments on track

DIGITAL SKILLS

## Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

**Written for students, by students.**

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

**Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.**

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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# Why this pack exists

Group work fails when files are scattered across WhatsApp and nobody knows which version is final. This pack explains shared drives, document permissions, comments and suggestions, version history and offline access, plus a simple group workflow.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

## What you will be able to do

- Structure and share a Google Drive folder with correct permissions.
- Collaborate in Docs and Sheets using comments and suggestions.
- Recover earlier versions and avoid conflicting copies.
- Set up a group workflow with clear ownership and deadlines.

## How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

## Organise and share

A predictable folder structure saves more time than any productivity app.

- One master folder per course or project, with subfolders for drafts, sources and final.
- Name files consistently: course, topic, version, date.
- Viewer for readers, commenter for reviewers, editor only for active contributors.
- Share the folder rather than individual files so new files inherit access.
- Use a shared calendar for deadlines and meetings.
- Remove access at the end of the project.

## Collaborate without duplicates

Simultaneous editing works when you use the tools designed for it.

- Use comments for feedback and suggestions mode for edits you want reviewed.
- Do not email multiple copies; edit the single shared document.
- Use version history to see who changed what and restore an earlier state.
- Assign sections to specific people with deadlines in the document.
- Turn on offline access for documents you may need without data.
- Keep a final PDF copy for submission so formatting does not shift.

> **Final means final**
> Rename the submitted file 'FINAL' and move it out of the drafts folder. Weeks later, you will know exactly what you submitted.

## Data, storage and etiquette

Cloud tools are convenient but not free of limits or risk.

- Free storage is limited; compress large images and clear old videos.
- Do not upload sensitive personal documents to shared folders.
- Check that a link is restricted before posting it publicly.
- Use two-factor authentication on the account.
- Respect bandwidth: avoid large uploads during peak hours on shared networks.
- Back up critical files locally or in a second service.

## Cloud tools are for working together

A shared cloud document changes collaboration from sending versions by email to editing one file together. That eliminates "final_v3_edited" confusion, but it introduces new problems: accidental deletion, unclear ownership, and edits nobody can trace.

The fix is conventions. Name files consistently (course-date-topic), keep one folder per course, and agree who owns which document. Use comments for discussion and the document itself for content, so that the final text is not buried under debate.

Version history is the safety net. Learn where it is and how to restore a previous version before you need it. It is the single most useful feature in any cloud document and almost nobody uses it until something is lost.

## The tools and their real uses

Docs for writing, Sheets for data and calculation, Slides for presentation, Forms for surveys and quizzes, Drive for storage and sharing, and Calendar for scheduling. Each has a mobile app, but long documents and spreadsheets are far easier on a laptop.